

SPORTSTAR OF THE YEAR (FEMALE)

Preethi Pal

Age: 24



Discipline: **Athletics (T35)***

**The T35 classification is for athletes with coordination impairments such as hypertonia, ataxia, and athetosis.*

Born with weak legs and an irregular posture, few in her village expected Preethi Pal to even survive. At the Paris 2024 Paralympics, Preethi set the tone for India's

athletics contingent. The 23-year-old from Meerut clinched a bronze medal in the women's 100m T35 event with a personal best time of 14.21 seconds. Not only was this India's first athletics medal at the Paris Paralympics, but it also marked the first time an Indian stood on the podium for a track event in Paralympic history. Preethi also won a bronze in the 200m event in the same classification, making her the second Indian woman to win two Paralympic medals at the same edition. Earlier in March, she won two golds at the Indian Open Para Athletics Championships and later won two bronze medals at the World Para Athletics Championships in Kobe, Japan.

Achievements in 2024 season:

- ✪ Won two bronze medals at the Paris Paralympics
- ✪ Won India's first track medal in Paralympic history
- ✪ Became the second Indian woman to win two Paralympic medals in the same edition
- ✪ Won India's first athletics medal at the Paris Paralympics
- ✪ Won two golds at the Indian Open Para Athletics Championships
- ✪ Won bronze medals at the World Para Athletics Championships

Deepthi Jeevanji

Age: 21



Discipline: **Athletics (T20)***

**T20 classification is for athletes with intellectual impairment.*

Deepthi Jeevanji came into the limelight earlier this year when she shattered the women's 400m

T20 world record on her way to winning gold at the World Para Athletics Championships in Kobe. As she made her Paralympic debut, the 21-year-old from Kalleda village in Warangal emerged as one of India's top prospects in track events—and she did not disappoint. Deepthi dominated her heats, qualifying for the final as the heat one topper. However, Türkiye's Aysel Onder broke her world record of 55.07 seconds in another heat, setting the stage for a thrilling final. As the final race unfolded, Deepthi seemed poised to secure a historic silver medal, but Onder surged past her at the finish line, with Ukraine's Yuliia Shuliar claiming gold. With this achievement, Deepthi became only the second Indian athlete to win a medal in a track event at the Paralympic Games. In 2023, she had already showcased her talent by winning gold in the 400m T20 category at the Hangzhou Para Asian Games, where she set an Asian record with a time of 56.69 seconds.

Achievements in the 2024 season:

- ✪ Held the world record for the women's 400m T20 event (was eventually broken)
- ✪ Won gold at the World Para Athletics Championships 2024
- ✪ Won bronze at the Paris Paralympics
- ✪ Second Indian to win a Paralympic medal in a track event